Superstore Sales Performance

Key findings and recommendations from the Power BI dashboard

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1. Scope and data

This report summarises the results of a three-page Power BI dashboard built on the Tableau Sample Superstore dataset, which describes a fictional US retailer of office supplies, furniture and technology products. The analysis covers 9,993 order lines (5,009 orders from 793 customers) placed between January 2023 and December 2026.

Two cleaning decisions affect the figures. The newer version of the dataset includes 200 Canadian order lines; these were excluded because the business case concerns the US operation and because the rows contained inconsistent customer IDs. One order line that was an exact duplicate of another (apart from its row ID) was also removed.

Over the full period the company generated $2.30M in sales and $286.4K in profit, a profit margin of 12.5%. The average order was worth $458.56 and the average discount per order line was 15.6%.

2. Findings

2.1 Sales grew by about half in three years, with a clear seasonal pattern

Sales rose from $484.0K in 2023 to $733.2K in 2026, an increase of 51.5%. The only decline came in 2024 (−2.8%), followed by growth of 29.5% in 2025 and 20.4% in 2026. The pattern within each year is consistent: sales peak in September and again in November and December, and are at their lowest in January and February. Only two of the 48 months ended with a loss (July 2023 and January 2024).

2.2 Deep discounts go together with low or negative margins

The sub-categories sold with small discounts are the most profitable: Labels (average discount 6.9%, margin 44.4%), Paper (7.5%, 43.4%) and Envelopes (8.0%, 42.3%). At the other end, the three sub-categories with average discounts above 20% have the weakest results: Machines (30.6%, margin 1.8%), Tables (26.1%, margin −8.6%) and Bookcases (21.1%, margin −3.0%).

The relationship is strong but not universal. Binders carry the highest average discount (37.2%) and still earn a 14.9% margin. Supplies lose money (margin −2.5%) even though their average discount is only 7.7%, which suggests a pricing or cost problem rather than a discount problem.

2.3 Furniture sells well but barely makes money

Furniture accounts for 32% of sales ($741.7K) but only 6% of profit ($18.5K), a margin of 2.5% against roughly 17% for both Office Supplies and Technology. Tables (−$17.7K) and Bookcases (−$3.5K) are the main reasons. Across the whole range, 299 products are loss-making, and two of the ten best-selling products, the Cisco TelePresence EX90 and the GBC DocuBind P400, are also among the ten largest loss-makers.

2.4 Ten high-discount states cancel out a third of the profit

The West is the largest region ($725.5K in sales) and has the highest margin (14.9%). In contrast, ten states end the period with a loss, and every one of them has an average discount between 28% and

39%, roughly twice the company average of 15.6%. Together these states generate 31% of sales ($705.4K) but lose $98.2K, an amount equal to 34% of the company's total profit.

The four largest losses are in Texas (−$25.7K, average discount 37.0%), Ohio (−$17.0K, 32.5%), Pennsylvania (−$15.6K, 32.9%) and Illinois (−$12.6K, 39.0%). Texas stands out because it is also one of the largest state markets, with $170.2K in sales.

2.5 The customer base is broad, and Corporate customers spend most per head

The ten largest customers generate only 6.7% of sales, so the business does not depend on a small number of accounts. Consumer is the largest segment in every region and accounts for 50.6% of sales, but the average Corporate customer spends more ($2,992 against $2,840 for Consumer). Sales and profit leaders are not always the same people: the top customer by sales ($25.0K) does not appear in the top ten by profit, while the second customer by sales is first by profit ($9.0K).

3. Recommendations

3.1 Set discount limits for low-margin sub-categories

Introduce a maximum discount for Tables, Bookcases and Machines (for example 20%) and require manager approval above that level. The limit should be set per sub-category rather than company-wide, since Binders show that higher discounts can be sustainable where margins allow it. The Discount vs Profit Margin chart in the dashboard can be used to track the effect month by month.

3.2 Review pricing and the product range

Review prices and supplier costs for Tables, Bookcases and Supplies, as well as for the individual loss-making products that sell in high volumes. Products that remain unprofitable after repricing should either be withdrawn or sold only as part of bundles with profitable items.

3.3 Run a profitability plan for the loss-making states

Start with Texas, Ohio, Pennsylvania and Illinois, which together lose $70.9K. Apply the discount limits there first, compare their discount practices and product mix with the West, and agree a margin target with each Regional Manager. As an indication of the size of the opportunity: if the ten loss-making states only broke even, total profit would rise from $286.4K to about $384.6K and the overall margin from 12.5% to 16.7%.

4. Notes and limitations

1. Superstore is a synthetic teaching dataset, so the findings show the analytical approach rather than describe a real company.
2. The link between discounts and losses is a strong association, not proven cause and effect. Product mix may also play a role in the loss-making states. A controlled change in discount levels would be the way to confirm it.
3. The dataset contains no sales targets or cost breakdowns, so target achievement and cost drivers could not be analysed.
4. The break-even figure in 3.3 is an illustrative calculation, not a forecast.